

Letter To My Mama

By Lucia Lorenz

Dear Mama,

I wonder why you agreed to give me a name you didn't even like.

You once told me how you and Dad spent three days in the hospital, the fluorescent lights buzzing overhead, arguing about what to call me. My arrival into the world was already an argument between you two. If that wasn't a sign, I don't know what is.

You said you'd always loved the name Lucy, and that when you had my sister Olivia with your ex-husband, he wouldn't let you use it. So I became the next daughter in line for the name you couldn't give before.

When I was born, you told me Dr. Banks said I "looked like a Lucy." I still don't know what that means. Was it a compliment? A prediction? Or just an easy way to narrow down the options? How can a red, wrinkled newborn already "look like" something? Maybe I'm just cynical, but I've always suspected he knew your name list before he ever made that comment.

Dad, meanwhile, wanted to name me Sofia, specifically after the actress Sophia Loren, a Hollywood sex symbol from the 1950s. A woman he was openly attracted to. You hated the idea immediately. I guess I should thank you for that, because I don't know how I'd feel being named after a woman my father thought was hot.

Even though the two of you wrestled over a first name, you agreed on my middle name fast. Which makes sense, middle names don't seem to carry as much pressure; they're said less, written less, fought over less.

You chose Maria. On its own, I don't care much for the name, but it filled the requirement for a version of Mary. All the women in your family had one: Mary in their first name, or middle name. It was stitched into everything, birth certificates, church programs, sweaters from childhood. I always felt like I was stepping into a mold.

I hated that tradition. The sameness, the lack of individuality, the sense that I was inheriting not a name but an expectation.

On the third day in the hospital, Dad found the name Lucia in a glossy Polish baby-name book. In Polish, it's pronounced Loo-stya, but he preferred the Italian pronunciation Loo-cha.

You didn't like it, said it was too hard to pronounce, but you compromised with him.

"As long as everyone still calls her Lucy." You said.

To this day, you never call me Lucia.

Whenever someone else does, a teacher, a coworker, a stranger calling my name across a room, you look over automatically, eyebrows raised, and say, "Just call her Lucy." Every time my stomach drops, it feels like I'm being misplaced.

I wonder why you never liked that name. Was it the name itself, or the fact that Dad chose it? Do you know how it stings each time you correct someone, as if my real name is somehow wrong?

Your loving daughter,
Lucia